



led by an ammunition technical officer—visiting various port warehouses and inland container yards across the country. Explosive-containing scrap was carefully identified at this stage. This sort of scrap was once regularly imported into India without any check, until an accident in 2004. That year, an explosion at Bhushan Steel and Strips in Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, killed 10 workers who were melting down artillery shells. The MHA halted imports, and port authorities seized hundreds of container loads worth of scrap. This material was then transferred to godowns, where it lay for 16 years while the bureaucracy debated its fate.

From Mumbai alone, army teams recovered 900 tonnes of potentially explosive scrap from 16 sites, including container yards at Wadala and Sewri, near densely populated areas. In March 1993, Pakistan's ISI had smuggled two tonnes of RDX into India and used members of the Dawood Ibrahim crime syndicate to plant and trigger serial explosions in 12 locations across Mumbai, killing 257 people. Years later, it would seem, all a terrorist would have needed was to steal some scrap from a government yard to improvise an explosive device. Extracting explosives from scrap is theoretically uncomplicated, something like extracting wax from a cylinder. Properly done, the TNT can be safely steamed out, with the dissolved material strained and then dried into blocks of military-grade material. (In recent years, Iraqi and Syrian insurgents have used old artillery shells to fabricate IEDs, or improvised explosive devices). "A terrorist would not even have had to smuggle RDX into the country—it was already here," a defence official repeats.

In Beirut, the ammonium nitrate that exploded had been taken off a merchant ship six years prior, and had been left unattended in a warehouse. In India, the story was much the same—except that alarm bells continued to ring, the last being in 2019, when a CAG (Comptroller and Auditor General of India) report identified dangerous material lying uncleared at various depots. The report noted 469 containers of hazardous waste 'lying undisposed for periods ranging from one to 17 years as on March 31, 2017.'

The explosion in Beirut provoked serious urgency and alarm among Indian officials. However, the task of sifting through hundreds of tonnes of scrap for undetonated ordnance was beyond the capabilities of the MHA's paramilitary organisations, including the army-staffed and run National Security Guard. So, in December 2020, the MHA turned to the army itself.

Between February and April 2021, Army Ordnance Corps teams from the Central Ammunition Depot (CAD) in Pulgaon, Maharashtra, fanned out to warehouses and storage sites across the country. They painstakingly segregated and neutralised the explosives found among the hundreds of tonnes of war scrap, preparing it for transport back to CAD. A separate drill was conducted at Pulgaon to destroy the dangerous material at the facility's 1,700-acre disposal ground. The task of safely neutralising the thousands of shells and explosives was completed in February 2022.

THE ARMY HAS RECOVERED 900 TONNES OF POTENTIALLY EXPLOSIVE SCRAP FROM MUMBAI ALONE

The operation was kept secret, even within the military: "The information was closely guarded to prevent panic," explains Lt General R.K.S. Kushwaha, director general of the Ordnance Corps. While matters could have ended very differently, this time, India's cautionary tale of bureaucratic dithering fortunately had a happy ending. ■